

Exploring Literacy as Power: Bridging Social Justice and Critical Communication

10 possible points (Last Revised Jan. 2026)

In this assignment, you'll dive into the intersection of literacy and social justice, exploring how literacy can either empower or exclude communities. This project gives you a chance to critically reflect on the role of literacy in social change

Objective:

To engage in critical analysis and examine the role literacy plays in communicating social justice issues, with an emphasis on how literacy can either empower or exclude communities.

Instructions: Organize the following components in a format of your choosing. (ex: presentation/paper/ podcast, etc)

Research & Documentation:

- Identify and define a historically relevant social justice topic in your field of study or local community. Why is this issue important to draw attention to?
- Collect relevant sources, such as articles, reports, community narratives, and online discussions about the issue. Cite these sources!
- Pay attention to the language, tone, and terminology used in the sources.

Conduct a Critical Analysis:

- Investigate and detail how literacy influences the way this issue is communicated to the public.
- Examine whether specific jargon or terminology might exclude certain groups from understanding or engaging with the issue.
- Consider how the literacy levels of different audiences impact the effectiveness of communication.

Connect Issue to the Present: Connect to a social media **campaign, article, or initiative** related to your selected issue and analyze the following. **Include images/ screenshots:**

- The target audience and their expected literacy levels.
- The strategies used to make the information accessible and understandable.
- Potential communication barriers caused by literacy challenges.
- All of this is included in the reflection

Recommendations:

Propose strategies to address an existing gap in communication about the issue you chose. Ensure these strategies are inclusive and accessible to a broad audience, regardless of literacy levels. Consider using multimedia, simplifying language, or facilitating community-based dialogue.

Critical Reflection:

Reflect on your findings (this is a synthesis of the issue, the research and documentation, the critical analysis, the connecting artifact such as a social media campaign, an article or an initiative as well as your recommendations). Reflect on the importance of literacy in mediating social justice issues, drawing on personal experiences or observations that have shaped your understanding.

Samples of student work

Criteria	Exceeding Expectations	Meeting Expectations (full credit)	Approaching Expectations	Below Expectations
Research & Documentation 3	Topic is clearly defined. Uses a wide range of high-quality, diverse sources. Sources are highly relevant and effectively support the analysis. Demonstrates thorough research. Sources are referenced and cited appropriately.	Topic is clearly defined. Uses appropriate and relevant sources that adequately support the analysis. Some diversity in sources. Sources are referenced and cited appropriately.	Topic is defined but a limited number of sources, some of which may not be fully relevant or supportive of the analysis. Research is minimal. Sources are at times referenced but may be limited in scope and/ or not cited appropriately.	Topic is not clearly defined. Few or no sources used, or sources are irrelevant and do not contribute to the analysis. Little to no research evident. Sources are not referenced and cited appropriately.
Critical Analysis 3	Insightful and thorough analysis that demonstrates deep understanding of the role of literacy in mediating social justice. Critical thinking is clearly articulated and consistently applied throughout.	Solid analysis with clear understanding of the issue. Critical thinking is present and clearly articulated.	Some analysis, but lacks depth. Critical thinking is present but limited or underdeveloped. Surface-level understanding of the issue.	Minimal or no critical analysis. Shows little to no understanding of the issue or the role literacy plays in mediating social justice.
Connect Issue to Present 3	Provides a detailed connection and analysis of the social media campaign, article, or initiative, clearly identifying the target audience, their literacy levels, and effective strategies used to ensure accessibility. Thoroughly discusses potential communication barriers caused by literacy challenges with specific examples. Images/ Screenshots included.	Analyzes the campaign, article, or initiative, identifying the target audience and their literacy levels. Discusses strategies for accessibility and communication barriers. Images/ Screenshots included.	Provides basic analysis, with limited discussion on the target audience, literacy levels, and strategies for accessibility. Communication barriers are mentioned but not fully explored. Images/ Screenshots were not included.	Minimally addresses the campaign, article, or initiative. Lacks analysis of target audience, literacy levels, and accessibility strategies. Communication barriers are not addressed Images/ .Screenshots not included.
Recommendations 2	Proposes highly creative, practical, and actionable strategies for improving communication. Ideas are innovative and well-supported by analysis.	Proposes reasonable and practical strategies for improving communication. Ideas are well-thought-out and fully developed.	Proposes some strategies, but they may lack practicality, depth, or clear connection to the analysis. Ideas are underdeveloped and/or may lack creativity.	Recommendations are missing, vague, or impractical. Ideas are not connected to the analysis or show little effort.
Reflection (Insight and Personal Connection) 2	Reflection is highly insightful and demonstrates deep personal connection to the issue. New insights are clearly articulated and supported by thoughtful reflection.	Reflection shows insight and personal connection to the issue. Some new insights are presented and growth is articulated.	Reflection shows minimal insight or personal connection to the issue. Lacks depth or thoughtful consideration of the issue.	Reflection is missing, superficial, or lacks personal connection to the issue. Shows little to no insight.

Organization and Clarity 2(Presentation and Structure)	Exceptionally well-organized and clearly presented. Ideas flow logically, and writing or modality is engaging, coherent, and error-free.	Well-organized and clearly presented. Ideas generally flow well. Free from errors.	Some issues with organization or clarity. Writing or modality may be difficult to follow at times, and there may be noticeable errors.	Poorly organized or unclear. Writing or modality is hard to follow, and there are frequent errors.
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